

COMPLETE CHESS LEARNING LIBRARY

The Complete French Defense

Black-side chains, breaks, theory, counterplay, and difficult-bishop solutions

COURSE BOOK

30 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
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01. Advance Main Line



02 - Advance Variation

READ THE POSITION

White gains e5 space while Black attacks d4 from c5, c6, and b6.

PRIMARY PLAN

Increase pressure on d4, develop the c8-bishop, and play ...f6 only when e5 can be challenged safely.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White maintains the pawn chain, develops behind it, and attacks on the kingside.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7

MEMORY RULE

Advance French: attack the base d4 before striking the head e5.

01. Decision Framework

Advance Main Line

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The d4-pawn can be tactically defended by discovered attacks on the queen or c8-bishop.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Advance French: attack the base d4 before striking the head e5.

02. Advance with 6.a3



02 - Advance Variation

READ THE POSITION

White gains queenside space and protects b4 while Black reroutes the knight toward f5.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack d4, use ...Bd7 and ...Rc8, and make the queenside pawns into targets after the center clarifies.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses b4 and Bd3 to gain space and discourage queenside pressure.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. a3 Nh6 7. b4 cxd4 8. cxd4 Nf5

MEMORY RULE

Advance a3: let the queenside expansion create targets before opening files.

02. Decision Framework

Advance with 6.a3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Taking d4 too early can open lines that develop White's pieces with tempo.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

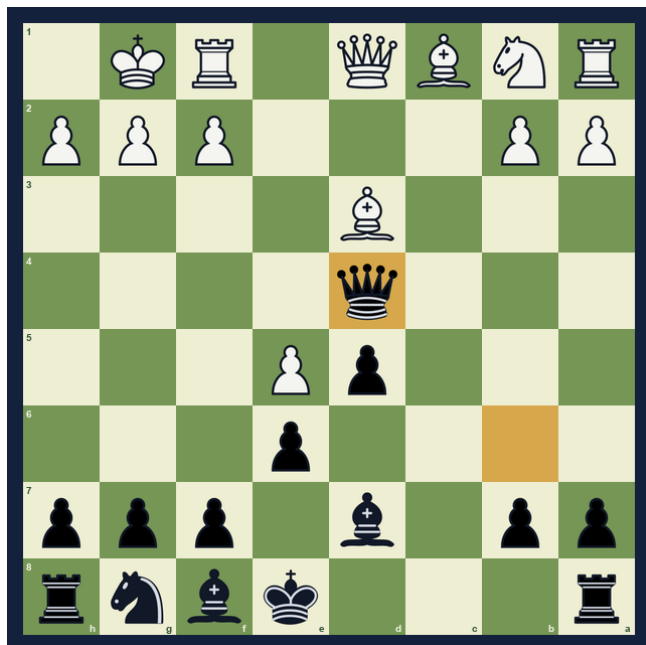
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Advance a3: let the queenside expansion create targets before opening files.

03. Milner-Barry Gambit



02 - Advance Variation

READ THE POSITION

White offers d4 to gain development and attacking lines against Black's uncastled king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Accept material only while completing development and be ready to return it to neutralize the initiative.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Nc3, Be3, and queen or rook pressure for rapid compensation.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Qb6 6. Bd3 cxd4 7. cxd4 Bd7 8. O-O Nxd4 9. Nxd4 Qxd4

MEMORY RULE

Milner-Barry: consolidate development, not the pawn.

03. Decision Framework

Milner-Barry Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The extra pawn is irrelevant if the queen blocks development and the king cannot castle.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Milner-Barry: consolidate development, not the pawn.

04. Advance Euwe Plan



02 - Advance Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black attacks e5 with ...f6 before committing the queen to b6.

PRIMARY PLAN

Complete development, pressure e5, and use the f-file only after the central exchanges are understood.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White protects the e5 wedge and may use c4 or Be3 to exploit Black's king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. c3 Nc6 5. Nf3 Bd7 6. Be2 f6 7. O-O fxe5 8. dxe5 Qc7

MEMORY RULE

Advance ...f6: calculate the recapture and king lines before touching the f-pawn.

04. Decision Framework

Advance Euwe Plan

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Opening the f-file also opens diagonals toward the black king.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Advance ...f6: calculate the recapture and king lines before touching the f-pawn.

05. Advance without c3



02 - Advance Variation

READ THE POSITION

White develops rapidly and allows a temporary central pawn imbalance instead of supporting d4 with c3.

PRIMARY PLAN

Take on d4 only when Black can survive the development gain and challenge e5 immediately.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses open lines, Nbd2, and quick castling to turn the pawn into activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Bd3 cxd4 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Advance without c3: judge the capture by tempi, not material.

05. Decision Framework

Advance without c3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A pawn capture that opens the e-file can be a development gift.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Advance without c3: judge the capture by tempi, not material.

06. Tarrasch 3...c5



03 - Tarrasch Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black creates an isolated-queen-pawn structure in exchange for active pieces and open lines.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop rapidly, use the e-file and c-file, and seek ...O-O before the isolated pawn becomes a target.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White blockades d4 or d5 and exchanges active pieces into a favorable ending.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 c5 4. exd5 exd5 5. Ngf3 Nc6 6. Bb5 Bd6 7. O-O Ne7

MEMORY RULE

Tarrasch ...c5: accept structure only with active development.

06. Decision Framework

Tarrasch 3...c5

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The isolated pawn can support tactics only while Black's pieces remain active.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Tarrasch ...c5: accept structure only with active development.

07. Tarrasch Closed 3...Nf6



03 - Tarrasch Variation

READ THE POSITION

White maintains e5 while Black attacks d4 with a standard French chain.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...c5, ...Qb6, and ...f6 according to White's development, while freeing the c8-bishop.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White builds kingside space and keeps the c-pawn available for support.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. e5 Nfd7 5. Bd3 c5 6. c3 Nc6 7. Ne2

MEMORY RULE

Closed Tarrasch: attack the chain before your own pieces become the cramped side.

07. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Closed 3...Nf6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The knight on d7 can block the bishop and queen if Black delays a break.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

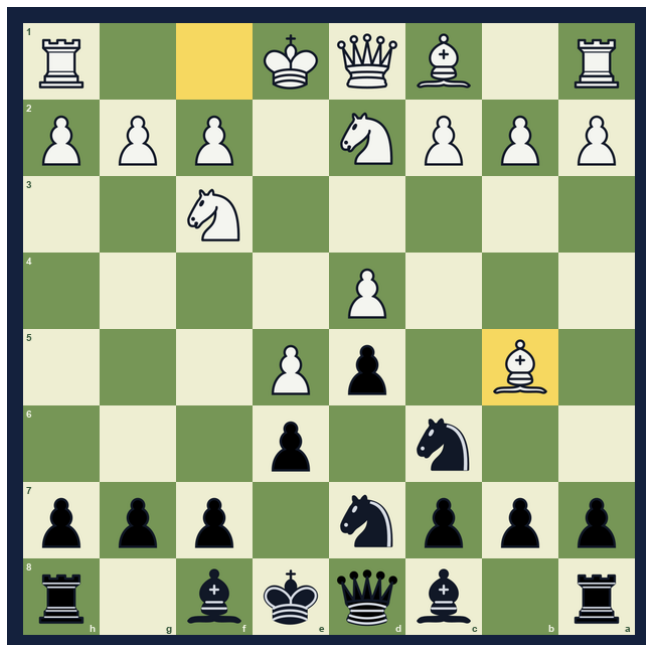
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Closed Tarrasch: attack the chain before your own pieces become the cramped side.

08. Tarrasch Guimard



03 - Tarrasch Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the queen knight first and provokes White to define the center and bishop.

PRIMARY PLAN

Pressure e5 with ...f6 and develop the c8-bishop through d7 or a6 after the center settles.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Bb5 and c3 to restrain the freeing moves.

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 Nc6 4. Ngf3 Nf6 5. e5 Nd7 6. Bb5

MEMORY RULE

Guimard: develop actively, but preserve the ...c5 lever.

08. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Guimard

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The c6-knight can obstruct ...c5 if Black does not choose the break order carefully.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Guimard: develop actively, but preserve the ...c5 lever.

09. Tarrasch Rubinstein



03 - Tarrasch Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black releases the central tension and aims for a solid development scheme without a space battle.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...Ngf6, ...Be7, and ...O-O, then challenge the active e4-knight without conceding development.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White enjoys freer pieces and may build Bd3, O-O, and Qe2 before Black equalizes.

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nd2 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Nd7 5. Nf3 Ngf6

MEMORY RULE

Rubinstein Tarrasch: solidity requires active development, not waiting.

09. Decision Framework

Tarrasch Rubinstein

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Passive piece placement can leave Black with no central break and a permanently bad bishop.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Rubinstein Tarrasch: solidity requires active development, not waiting.

10. Classical Steinitz



04 - Classical Variation

READ THE POSITION

White supports the e5 chain with f4 while Black attacks d4 and prepares a second break.

PRIMARY PLAN

Increase pressure with ...Qb6 and ...Nh6-f5, then use ...f6 when the king and e6-pawn are safe.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains kingside space and may use Qd2, long castling, and g4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. e5 Nfd7 5. f4 c5 6. Nf3 Nc6 7. Be3

MEMORY RULE

Steinitz: pressure d4 first, then undermine e5 with a prepared ...f6.

10. Decision Framework

Classical Steinitz

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The e6-pawn becomes a sacrifice target when Black opens the f-file carelessly.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Steinitz: pressure d4 first, then undermine e5 with a prepared ...f6.

11. Classical Burn



04 - Classical Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black releases the center and accepts a slightly passive structure for the bishop pair and solidity.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop quickly, challenge the e4-knight, and use ...Nd7 and ...O-O before seeking ...c5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses active development and pressure on the kingside and center.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 dxe4 5. Nxe4 Be7 6. Bxf6 Bxf6 7. Nf3

MEMORY RULE

Burn: the bishop pair matters only after Black catches up in development.

11. Decision Framework

Classical Burn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The f6-bishop can be hit by tempo if Black delays castling and central development.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

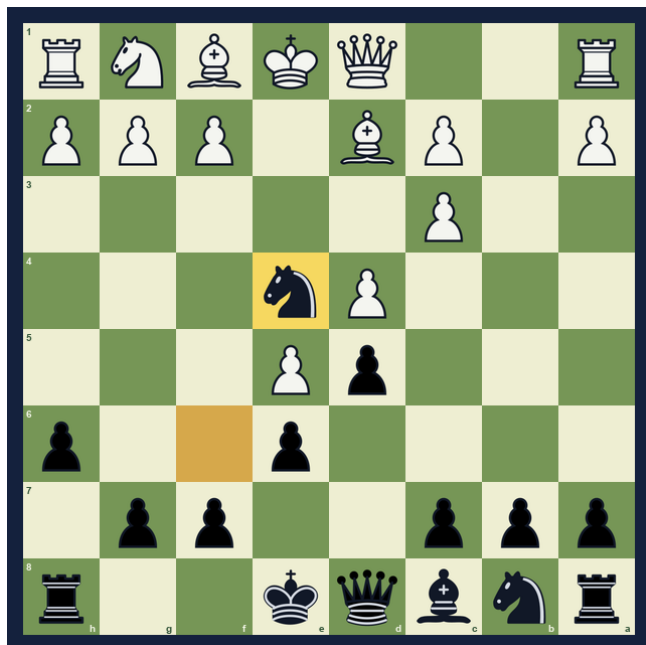
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Burn: the bishop pair matters only after Black catches up in development.

12. MacCutcheon Variation



04 - Classical Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black counterpins and damages White's queenside while accepting a sharp king and center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack c3 and d4, use ...c5, and decide king placement only after the center clarifies.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Qg4, the bishop pair, and kingside space against Black's uncastled king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Bb4 5. e5 h6 6. Bd2 Bxc3 7. bxc3 Ne4

MEMORY RULE

MacCutcheon: counterattack the center, but count every queen entry.

12. Decision Framework

MacCutcheon Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Queen attacks on g4 can hit g7 and e6 simultaneously.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: MacCutcheon: counterattack the center, but count every queen entry.

13. Alekhine-Chatard Attack



04 - Classical Variation

READ THE POSITION

White sacrifices a pawn or opens the h-file to accelerate an attack while Black challenges the advanced center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Return material if needed, exchange attacking pieces, and complete development before collecting more pawns.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Qg4, Bd3, and the h-file against the king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e5 Nfd7 6. h4 Bxg5 7. hxg5 Qxg5

MEMORY RULE

Chatard: king safety sets the value of the extra pawn.

13. Decision Framework

Alekhine-Chatard Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Castling short can step directly onto the open h-file and queen battery.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Chatard: king safety sets the value of the extra pawn.

14. Classical 4.Bg5 Be7



04 - Classical Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black accepts a space disadvantage but removes the pin and keeps a sound center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...c5, ...Nc6, and ...f6 to challenge the chain while giving the queen and knight useful squares.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses f4, Nf3, and Qd2 with kingside space.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e5 Nfd7 6. Bxe7 Qxe7 7. f4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Classical Be7: unpin first, then free the position before White completes the attack.

14. Decision Framework

Classical 4.Bg5 Be7

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The queen on e7 can obstruct the f8-bishop and become exposed to Nb5 or f5.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

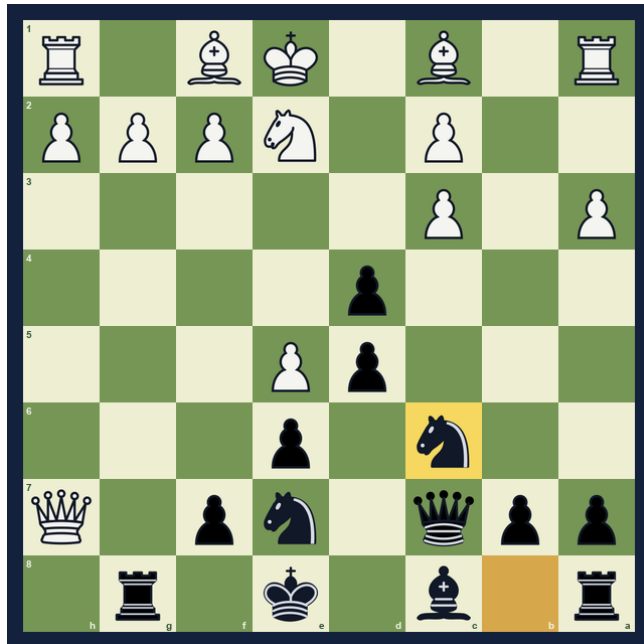
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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Classical Be7: unpin first, then free the position before White completes the attack.

15. Winawer Poisoned Pawn



05 - Winawer Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black sacrifices kingside pawns to attack White's center and exploit the exposed queen and damaged c-pawns.

PRIMARY PLAN

Open the center rapidly, develop with tempo, and use the g-file before White consolidates the extra material.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White tries to survive the initiative and convert extra pawns with the bishop pair.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e5 c5 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. bxc3 Ne7 7. Qg4 Qc7 8. Qxg7 Rg8 9. Qxh7 cxd4 10. Ne2 Nbc6

MEMORY RULE

Poisoned Pawn: compensation is development plus targets, not mystique.

15. Decision Framework

Winawer Poisoned Pawn

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Every tempo against the queen matters, but a missed check can leave Black simply down material.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

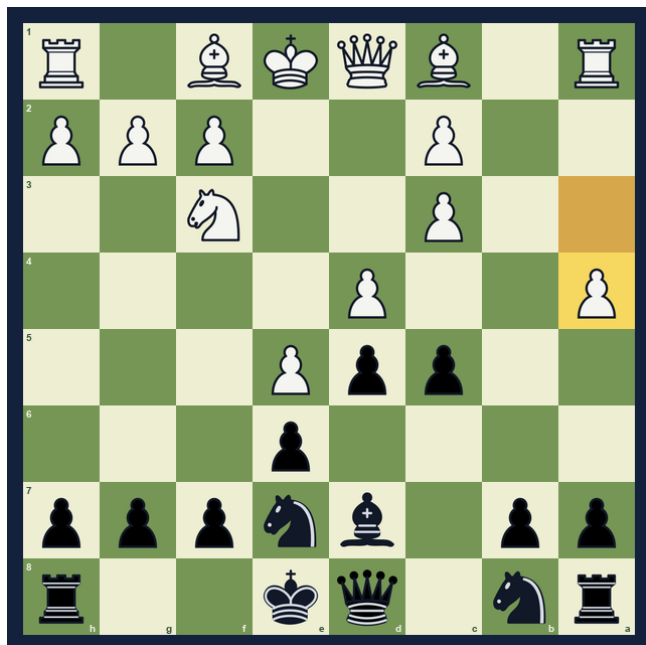
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Poisoned Pawn: compensation is development plus targets, not mystique.

16. Winawer Positional 7.Nf3



05 - Winawer Variation

READ THE POSITION

White accepts doubled c-pawns but keeps the queen home and uses the bishop pair and space.

PRIMARY PLAN

Pressure c3 and d4, use ...Qa5 or ...Nbc6, and improve the c8-bishop before entering an ending.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Ba3, Bd3, and h4 while the center remains closed.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e5 c5 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. bxc3 Ne7 7. Nf3 Bd7 8. a4

MEMORY RULE

Positional Winawer: fix the doubled pawns before simplifying.

16. Decision Framework

Winawer Positional 7.Nf3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Trading queens too early can leave Black with no way to attack the c-pawns.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

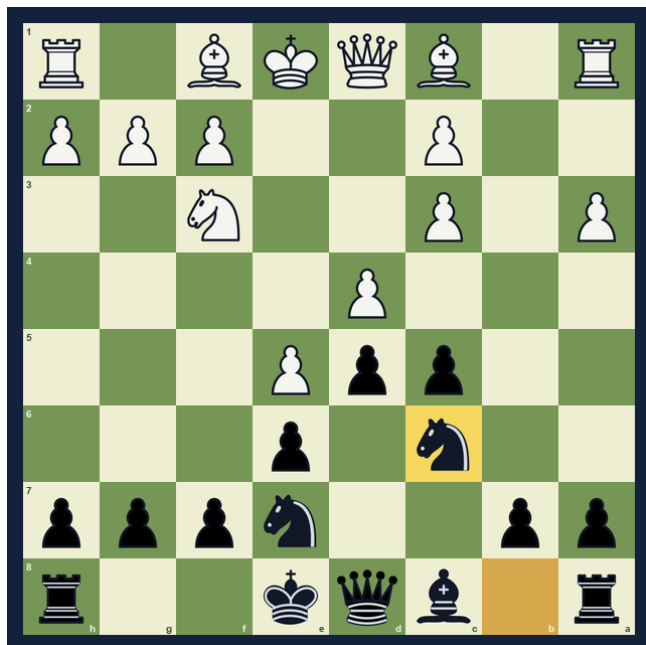
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Positional Winawer: fix the doubled pawns before simplifying.

17. Winawer Main Development



05 - Winawer Variation

READ THE POSITION

Black damages White's queenside and develops quickly while the pawn chain locks the center.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack d4 and c3 with ...Qa5, ...Bd7, and ...Rc8, then use ...f6 against e5.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the bishop pair and kingside space to attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. e5 c5 5. a3 Bxc3+ 6. bxc3 Ne7 7. Nf3 Nbc6

MEMORY RULE

Winawer main: create targets, then activate the bad bishop before collecting them.

17. Decision Framework

Winawer Main Development

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The c8-bishop can remain trapped if Black attacks pawns without solving development.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Winawer main: create targets, then activate the bad bishop before collecting them.

18. Winawer 4.Bd2



05 - Winawer Variation

READ THE POSITION

White breaks the pin immediately and creates tactical queen pressure rather than closing with e5.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use development and the open g-file to gain time on the queen while stabilizing e4.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White attacks g7 and tries to exploit Black's uncastled king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 Bb4 4. Bd2 dxe4 5. Qg4 Nf6 6. Qxg7 Rg8 7. Qh6

MEMORY RULE

Winawer Bd2: use the queen excursion to develop with tempo.

18. Decision Framework

Winawer 4.Bd2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Winning a pawn with ...Qxd4 can expose the queen to long-castling tempi.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

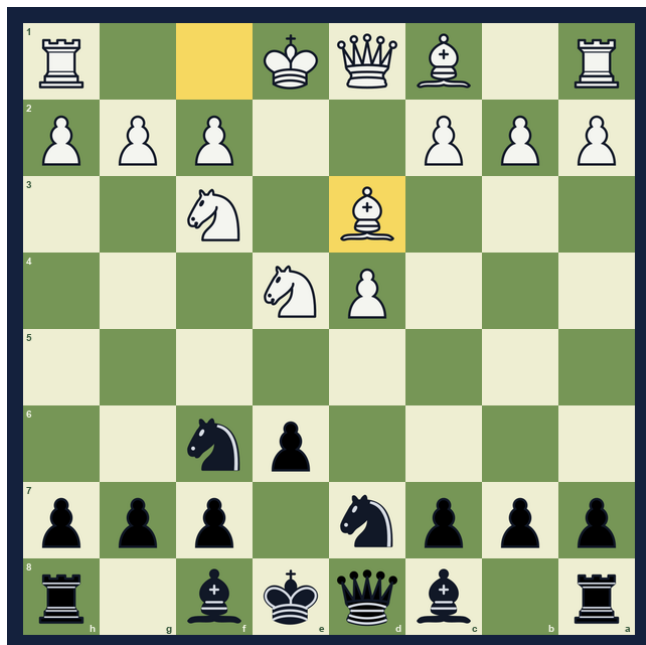
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Winawer Bd2: use the queen excursion to develop with tempo.

19. Rubinstein 3.Nc3



06 - Rubinstein and Fort Knox

READ THE POSITION

Black exchanges the central tension and aims for a compact position with no fixed pawn-chain target.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop the kingside, challenge e4, and play ...c5 before White turns the space edge into permanent activity.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White develops freely and may use Qe2, O-O, and Neg5.

REFERENCE LINE 1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Nd7 5. Nf3 Ngf6 6. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Rubinstein: remove the chain, then contest activity immediately.

19. Decision Framework

Rubinstein 3.Nc3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A passive ...Be7 and ...O-O setup can allow a kingside initiative if ...c5 never arrives.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

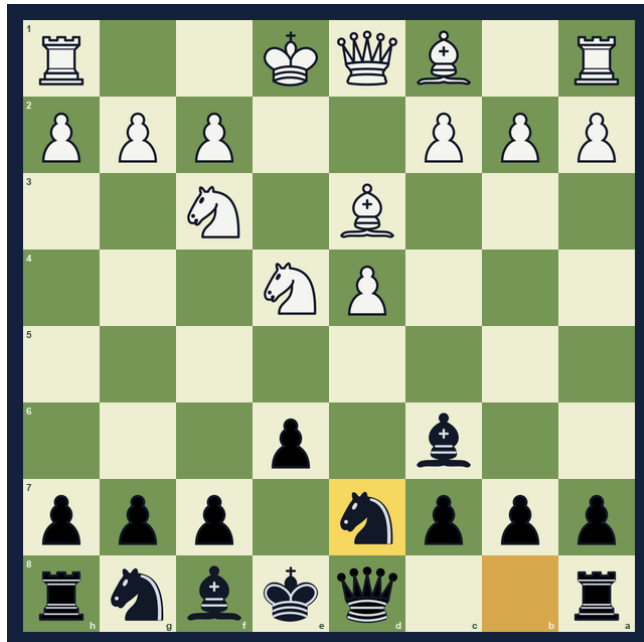
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Rubinstein: remove the chain, then contest activity immediately.

20. Fort Knox



06 - Rubinstein and Fort Knox

READ THE POSITION

Black develops the light bishop to c6 before the knight occupies d7, creating a very solid shell.

PRIMARY PLAN

Challenge e4, complete development, and use ...Ngf6 and ...Be7 without allowing White an uncontested attack.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains space and can target the slow kingside development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. Nc3 dxe4 4. Nxe4 Bd7 5. Nf3 Bc6 6. Bd3 Nd7

MEMORY RULE

Fort Knox: solidity works when the c6-bishop has an active exchange job.

20. Decision Framework

Fort Knox

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The bishop on c6 may become a target to Ne5 if Black cannot exchange the e4-knight.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Fort Knox: solidity works when the c6-bishop has an active exchange job.

21. Exchange Symmetrical Development



07 - Exchange Variation

READ THE POSITION

The symmetrical pawn structure shifts the battle to piece activity, file control, and asymmetric plans.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop without copying automatically, use ...c5 or ...Bg4, and create a useful imbalance before mass exchanges.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Bf4, Re1, and c4 to gain activity despite the symmetry.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 exd5 4. Nf3 Nf6 5. Bd3 Be7 6. O-O O-O

MEMORY RULE

Exchange French: symmetry is a structure, not a plan.

21. Decision Framework

Exchange Symmetrical Development

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Mechanical mirroring can lose a tempo when White creates the first concrete threat.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Exchange French: symmetry is a structure, not a plan.

22. Exchange with 4.c4



07 - Exchange Variation

READ THE POSITION

White transforms the Exchange into an isolated-queen-pawn or open-center game.

PRIMARY PLAN

Develop rapidly, pressure d4, and choose ...c6 or ...Be6 according to the recapture structure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses active pieces and cxd5 to gain open files and development.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 exd5 4. c4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Be7 6. Nf3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Exchange c4: treat it as an IQP opening, not a quiet French.

22. Decision Framework

Exchange with 4.c4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Defending d5 with passive pieces can concede the initiative without preserving the pawn.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Exchange c4: treat it as an IQP opening, not a quiet French.

23. Exchange with 4.Bd3



07 - Exchange Variation

READ THE POSITION

Both bishops face the kingside while Black develops the knight to e7 to avoid blocking the f-pawn.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...Nbc6, ...Bg4, and ...c6 or ...c5 to create a distinct plan.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White may use Re1, Ne5, and Qh5 against h7.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d4 d5 3. exd5 exd5 4. Bd3 Bd6 5. Nf3 Ne7 6. O-O O-O

MEMORY RULE

Exchange Bd3: develop with awareness of the h7 geometry.

23. Decision Framework

Exchange with 4.Bd3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Copying Bd6 can allow Bxh7+ tactics if the knight and queen are misplaced.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Exchange Bd3: develop with awareness of the h7 geometry.

24. King's Indian Attack



08 - Sidelines and Gambits

READ THE POSITION

White avoids the main center and builds a kingside fianchetto while Black occupies d5 and c5.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use space, complete development, and expand with ...b5 or ...e5 before White organizes e5 and a kingside attack.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses e5, Re1, and h4-h5 against the castled king.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. d3 d5 3. Nd2 Nf6 4. Ngf3 c5 5. g3 Nc6 6. Bg2 Be7 7. O-O O-O

MEMORY RULE

KIA: use the center to create counterplay before White closes it.

24. Decision Framework

King's Indian Attack

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Closing the center with ...d4 can give White a free kingside attack if Black has no queenside play.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

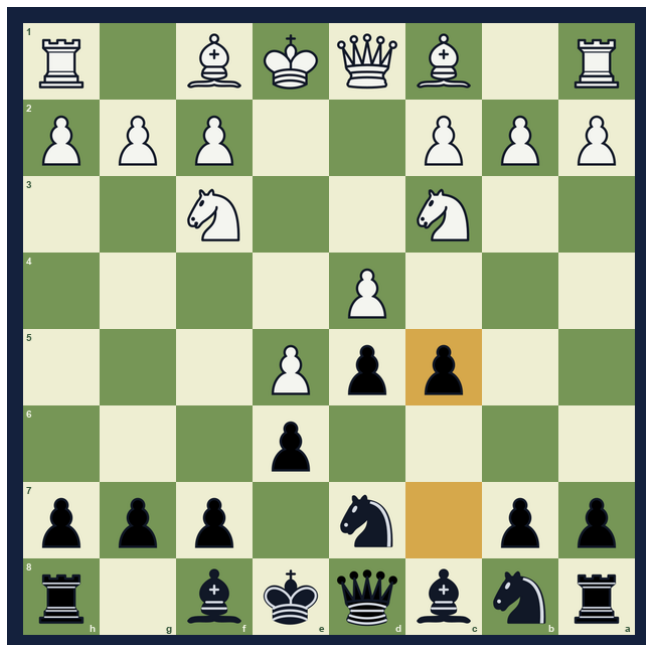
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: KIA: use the center to create counterplay before White closes it.

25. Two Knights Variation



08 - Sidelines and Gambits

READ THE POSITION

White develops both knights and reaches an Advance-style center without c3.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack d4 and e5 immediately while White's c-pawn and queen knight compete for central roles.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White gains development and may use Bb5 or Ne2-f4.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. Nf3 d5 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. e5 Nfd7 5. d4 c5

MEMORY RULE

Two Knights French: challenge the center before White coordinates it.

25. Decision Framework

Two Knights Variation

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	A careless ...cxd4 can open lines that make the c6-knight vulnerable.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

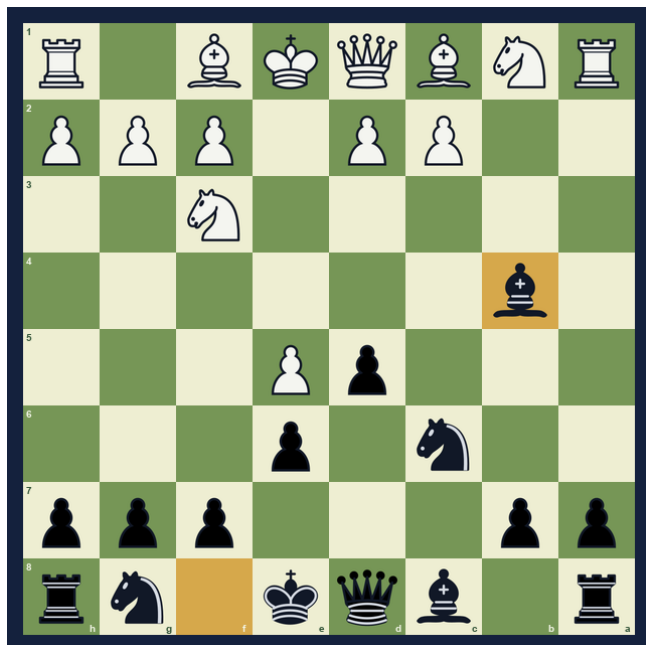
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Two Knights French: challenge the center before White coordinates it.

26. Wing Gambit



08 - Sidelines and Gambits

READ THE POSITION

White offers a wing pawn to distract the c-pawn and accelerate central development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Accept only while developing, then return material if needed to preserve the center and king.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses c3, d4, and open files for tempi on the bishop and queen.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. Nf3 d5 3. e5 c5 4. b4 cxb4 5. a3 Nc6 6. axb4 Bxb4

MEMORY RULE

French Wing Gambit: the pawn is temporary; development is the asset.

26. Decision Framework

Wing Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Holding b4 can trap the bishop or delay kingside development.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: French Wing Gambit: the pawn is temporary; development is the asset.

27. Orthoschnapp Gambit



08 - Sidelines and Gambits

READ THE POSITION

White opens the center immediately and offers the d5-pawn to gain development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack the advanced pawn with ...Nf6 and recover it while developing rather than with premature queen moves.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses Bb5+, Nc3, and rapid castling for activity.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. c4 d5 3. cxd5 exd5 4. exd5 Nf6

MEMORY RULE

Orthoschnapp: recover the pawn with pieces and development.

27. Decision Framework

Orthoschnapp Gambit

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Qxd5 can lose tempi to Nc3 and expose the queen to the e-file.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Orthoschnapp: recover the pawn with pieces and development.

28. Chigorin 2.Qe2



08 - Sidelines and Gambits

READ THE POSITION

White supports e4 and discourages a normal ...d5 capture but blocks the king bishop.

PRIMARY PLAN

Occupy the center, develop, and use ...c5 before White completes a slow kingside setup.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White aims for e5 or a reversed King's Indian Attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. Qe2 d5 3. d3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Be7 5. g3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Chigorin: take the center, then challenge the queen's restricted setup.

28. Decision Framework

Chigorin 2.Qe2

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The queen on e2 can support a tactical e5 push if Black ignores central preparation.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

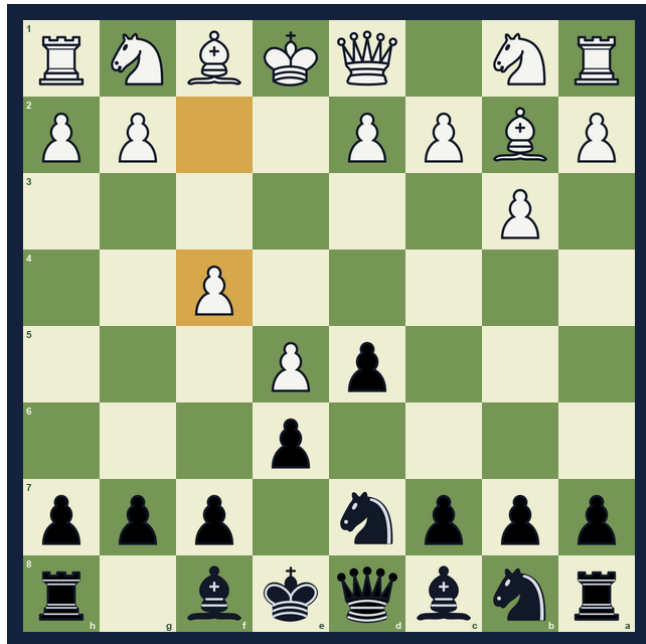
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Chigorin: take the center, then challenge the queen's restricted setup.

29. Steiner 2.b3



08 - Sidelines and Gambits

READ THE POSITION

White fianchettoes to pressure g7 and supports e5 with an unusual move order.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use ...c5 against d4 and e4, develop normally, and avoid weakening g7 without necessity.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White uses the b2-bishop and f4 for a kingside attack.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. b3 d5 3. Bb2 Nf6 4. e5 Nfd7 5. f4

MEMORY RULE

Steiner: challenge the center and leave the diagonal closed until ready.

29. Decision Framework

Steiner 2.b3

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	The long diagonal can make ...g6 or ...f6 tactically dangerous.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Steiner: challenge the center and leave the diagonal closed until ready.

30. La Bourdonnais 2.f4



08 - Sidelines and Gambits

READ THE POSITION

White builds an early kingside space structure but delays d4 support.

PRIMARY PLAN

Attack e5 and the dark squares with ...c5 and ...Nc6 while White's king remains in the center.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

White seeks f5 and a direct kingside initiative.

REFERENCE LINE

1. e4 e6 2. f4 d5 3. e5 c5 4. Nf3 Nc6

MEMORY RULE

Against 2.f4: undermine e5 before the attack gains development.

30. Decision Framework

La Bourdonnais 2.f4

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Prepare the central break with development; calculate the forced recapture and the first open-line move.
PIECE JOB	Give every piece a job that supports the center or the critical break.
TACTICAL WARNING	Opening the center helps Black only if the queen checks and e3 square are controlled.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only when the favorable feature survives the trade.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Simplify only when the healthier structure, better minor piece, or more active king survives the trade.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible decisions; move efficiently in familiar structures.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Against 2.f4: undermine e5 before the attack gains development.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.